

Reflective Writing

.....



What is reflective writing?

Reflective writing usually involves looking back at something, analysing a particular event or idea and thinking about what that event or idea means for students' ongoing journey during their studies and professional life. Reflection enables students and practitioners to look forward and make changes in order to get better at what they do.

What is the purpose of reflective writing?

The purpose of reflective writing is to help students learn from an experience. Students are able to make connections between theory and practice and can use these connections to inform what they do differently when experiencing a particular situation on repeat occasions. Reflective writing also provides students with an opportunity to provide evidence of learning and growing professional knowledge in order to show their audience what they have learned from the experience and why it was important for their academic and professional development (Moon 2006).

Skills required for a good reflection

Reflective writing provides you with the chance to think about what you are doing in a deeper and more critical way. Being able to think **critically** and **analytically** about a learning journey is a useful life skill for students and encourages them to make connections between different aspects of their work (Oxford Brookes n.d.).

When approaching criticality in reflection, it is important to consider the following:

What went well?

What didn't go well?

What have you learnt from your experience?

What is the significance of the experience?

Examples:

During my placement, I was put in a group of 4 and we were provided with a task. **Overall, the task went well** due to group members taking on extra workload, **however** there were elements **where communication was not always apparent**. For example, **one of the group members was absent from 3 out of 5 meetings and, often, did not provide us with a reason for their absence nor an update as to where they were with the work. This meant that the rest of us had to come up with a solution to avoid issues during the main presentation.** In order to prevent this from happening again, I would ensure a back-up plan was put in place at the start of the task to cover for unexpected absences...

The writer mentions what went well

Sentence connector that shows contrast and signals a counter point is coming

Problem is introduced

Problem is elaborated on

Impact of the problem is discussed

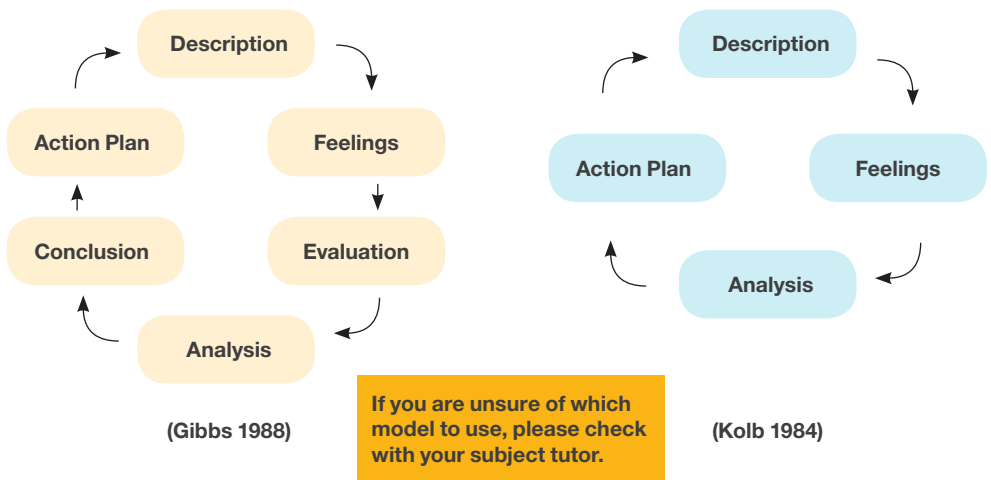
A recommendation is made to inform the reader of what will be done the next time a similar situation occurs



Models for Reflection

There are a number of models that can be used, however, below are some common cycles that may be recommended by your tutor. These models are designed to guide students towards organising and critically analysing their thoughts accordingly in order to create a coherent piece of writing.

Prior to writing your reflection, it is important to ask yourself whether you are to **use, choose or combine a framework** (Williams, Woolliams and Spiro 2012). For example, if you are to choose a framework, you may be asked to choose from a list which may include **The Gibbs Reflective Cycle (1988)** and **Kolb's Experimental Learning Cycle (1984)** which are outlined below.



Citations

The use of citations still applies in reflection as a significant part of reflection as a way of evidencing your learning. It shows your reader that you have engaged with the information provided by the source (Hyland 1999). When citing sources, consider the following:

- Have you used reliable academic sources to provide theories, models and examples to support your points?
- Have you included an alphabetically ordered reference list that matches your in text citations?
- Have you referenced your sources appropriately as per the Coventry University Harvard Style?

Language features of a reflection

Linking words and phrases

Using linking words and phrases can **improve the flow of your writing** and show the **connectedness** of the ideas contained in your work. Here are some commonly used linking words and phrases you might want to employ in your reflection:

Example: *I will be discussing my experience and progress at CU Coventry during the first 6 weeks of my course. **Firstly**, I will be talking about my experience during class. **Secondly**, I will be analysing the experiences by applying a reflective theory. **Finally**, I will be creating a personal development plan outlining my goals and objectives for the future.*

Example: *Overall, the task went well due to group members taking on extra workload, **however** there were elements where communication was not always apparent.*

The use of 'I'

When reflecting, it is normally appropriate to use the first person 'I', however it is important to bear in mind that reflective writing will almost always include third person as well e.g. Quinn (2017) suggests that...'. Always check your guidelines if you are not sure or ask your tutor.

References:

Moon, J. (2006) Learning journals. A handbook for reflective practice and professional development. London: Routledge

Oxford Brookes University (n.d.) Reflective Writing. [online] available from < <https://www.brookes.ac.uk/students/upgrade/study-skills/reflective-writing/> > [01/08/2018]

Hyland, K. (1999) 'Academic Attribution: Citation and the Construction of Disciplinary Knowledge'. Applied Linguistics 20(3), 341-367

Williams, K., Woolliams, M. and Spiro, J. (2012) Reflective Writing: Pocket Study Skills. New York: Palgrave Macmillan